

Medicines for constipation

These medicines help treat constipation (hard stools).

What medicine do I take?

- There are different types of constipation medicines.
 - Bulk forming laxatives, such as methylcellulose, polycarbophil, and psyllium
 - Lubricant laxatives, such as mineral oil
 - Osmotic laxatives, such as glycerin suppositories, magnesium hydroxide, and polyethylene glycol
 - Stimulant laxatives, such as bisacodyl, castor oil, and sennosides
 - Stool softeners, such as docusate sodium
- Talk to your doctor or nurse if you do not know the names of your medicine.

What does this medicine do?

- Helps your bowels move
- Keeps you from having problems with constipation
 - Bulking agents help your body make more stool and make stool easier to pass.
 - Lubricant laxatives make stool slick to make it easier to pass.
 - Osmotic laxatives help make the stool softer and easier to pass.
 - Stimulant laxatives make stool move faster through the intestines. This type of laxative is not supposed to be taken regularly.
 - Stool softeners help make stool soft and easier to pass.

How do I take this medicine?

- Ask your doctor if you have any questions about taking these medicines.
- Constipation medicine can be taken many ways.
 - Most constipation medicines are pills or liquids taken by mouth.

- Powder forms can be mixed with water or other liquids.
 - Suppositories are taken in the rear end (rectum).
- Take your medicine as directed.
 - Some constipation medicines should be taken first thing in the morning or before bedtime.
 - Never take more than the recommended dose.
 - Ask your doctor or pharmacist if you are unsure how to take the medicine.
- Drink lots of water or other fluids while taking medicines for constipation.
- Stop taking laxatives when constipation improves.

What are the side effects?

- Common side effects:
 - Stomach (abdominal) cramps
 - Bloating or gas
 - Loose stools (diarrhea)
- Serious side effects:
 - Low body fluids (dehydration)
 - Muscle cramps or pain
 - Weakness
 - Severe stomach cramps
 - Very loose stools (bad diarrhea) that last for more than 1 day
 - Abnormal heartbeat (arrhythmia)
 - Blood potassium level that is too high or too low
- Some laxatives can cause problems with how your body absorbs nutrients. This can lead to serious problems, such as heart problems, weakness, confusion, or seizures (body shaking, staring, eyes rolling).

Do I need to take special steps when taking this medicine?

- Talk to your doctor about what type of medicine to take for constipation and when to take it.
 - Some constipation medicines should not be taken with other medicines or supplements.
 - Do not give a child a constipation medicine without asking the child's doctor if it is OK.
- Take constipation medicines only when you need to.
 - Do not take them regularly unless your doctor tells you to.
 - Regular use of laxatives can change your body's ability to absorb vitamin D and calcium.
 - Sodium phosphate laxatives should only be used once a day and for no longer than 3 days.
- Talk to your doctor if you take a constipation medicine and still do not have a bowel movement.

This information is general in nature and may not apply to you or your condition. Talk to your doctor or nurse about how to best use this information and how to take care of your medical condition. Be sure to ask your doctor or nurse any questions you might have. This information sheet is not intended to provide or replace professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment.

Patient or Caregiver:

Signature: _____ Date: _____

Nurse:

Signature: _____ Date: _____